Leon Bridges Tries a New Sound on 'Happiness Anytime'

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Leon Bridges became known in 2015 with his first album, Coming Home. Its **retro-soul** and R&B songs became his signature sound. Eleven years later, he is trying something new. His fifth studio album is called Happiness Anytime. It brings in **Afrobeats**, Brazilian music and **disco**.

On the new album, Bridges uses a live band and electronic sounds instead of mostly playing **acoustic guitar**. He hopes the music will make people dance. "That's what was beautiful about this album. We didn't know what we wanted to make going into it," he told Morning Edition. "But, you know, it was all about cultivating a new sound. And I felt that."

Bridges says the album shows his journey as he becomes a more complex musician. He talked with NPR's Michel Martin about finding joy in different cultures and about growing since his early career. For him, **reinvention** is the big idea: do not just repeat the old style, but mix in sounds from around the world.

Word Treasure

retro-soul -- New music made in the style of soul songs from long ago.

Afrobeats -- Upbeat popular music from West Africa with strong dance rhythms.

disco -- Dance music with a steady beat that was hugely popular in the 1970s.

acoustic guitar -- A guitar that makes its sound naturally, without electric power.

reinvention -- Changing yourself or your work into something new instead of repeating the old way.

Background you need

A studio album is a set of songs an artist records and releases together.

Musicians sometimes change their style from album to album so they can try new sounds and grow.

Radio interviews are a common way for artists to explain a new album and its ideas to fans.

Break it down

WHO: Leon Bridges, a singer known for retro-soul and R&B
WHAT: He released a fifth studio album, Happiness Anytime, that mixes in Afrobeats, Brazilian music and disco
WHERE: He explained the album in an interview with NPR's Michel Martin
WHY: He wants to grow as a musician and make people dance instead of just repeating his old style

Why it matters

Trying new things instead of always repeating what worked before is how artists -- and everyone -- keep growing.

Test what you remember

1. In which year did Leon Bridges become known with his first album, Coming Home?

- (A) 2020
- (B) 2015
- (C) 2026
- (D) 2010

2. What is Bridges' fifth studio album called?

- (A) Leon
- (B) Good Thing
- (C) Happiness Anytime
- (D) Coming Home

3. Which styles does the new album bring in?

- (A) Afrobeats, Brazilian music and disco
- (B) Country, jazz and blues
- (C) Classical and opera
- (D) Rock, punk and metal

4. What does Bridges mostly use on the new album instead of acoustic guitar?

- (A) A live band and electronic sounds
- (B) Only drums
- (C) A piano alone
- (D) An orchestra

5. What does Bridges hope the new music will make people do?

- (A) Sleep
- (B) Study
- (C) Travel
- (D) Dance

6. What does Bridges call the big idea of the album?

- (A) Going back to his first style
- (B) Working with a bigger record company
- (C) Reinvention -- mixing in sounds from around the world
- (D) Recording songs more quickly

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: A 4: A 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Leon Bridges: Said the album was about cultivating a new sound, hoped it would make people dance, and called reinvention the big idea.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):